the country's largest corporates, Videocon, loaned their field staff to set up the infrastructure for the Chai pe Charcha events. This again was quintessential Team Modi—plan in-house and then get an outside vendor with expertise to execute the project.

I didn't find the content of the charchas particularly news worthy. The questions asked had been carefully vetted. Most of the time, Modi would give lengthy answers, and no cross-questions were posed. As a journalistic exercise or an exercise in democratic questioning of a politician, it didn't really work. As a public relations ploy, though, it was a cracking success. Modi, the humble 'chaiwallah', was aspiring to be the country's prime minister—it was a classic poverty-to-power script that even Salim–Javed couldn't have bettered.

I realized just how effective Chai pe Charcha had been while covering the elections in south Bangalore. I was trying to get the usual vox pop on the street, asking people what they thought of Modi. At a local restaurant, a group of young men smiled at me and said, 'We are all with Modi,' and then holding up cups of tea, they exulted, 'Time for Chai pe Charcha!' If, in the heart of south Indian coffee country, tea was the flavour of the season, you knew something unique was happening.

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On 5 March, the Election Commission sounded the bugle for the sixteenth general elections. A nine-phase poll would be held from 7 April to 10 May, with the counting scheduled for 16 May. We had commissioned another election tracker in the week leading up to the announcement—once again, it showed the NDA steadily inching up, now crossing the 240-seat mark. The UPA was in danger of falling further behind. A Modi-led government now seemed inevitable. The only question raised in the television studio was whether Modi would have enough allies to form a coalition government, or would he be isolated like Vajpayee was in 1996, because of his 'communal' tag. On our expert panel, P. Sainath, the distinguished journalist, made a